

MODULE 23 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

Exam Mechanics

No product content. How AWS phrases questions, and how to read them.

SCOPE All domains TYPE Technique MODULE 23 of 26

You will meet questions where you know every service in the list and still pick the wrong one.

Qualifier words and what they point at

QUALIFIER	WHAT IT SIGNALS
MOST cost-effective	Cheapest option that still meets every stated requirement. Not just cheapest.
LEAST operational overhead	The most managed service. Serverless beats managed beats self-run.
MOST operationally efficient	Fewest moving parts and least ongoing human effort.
MOST secure	Tightest permissions and strongest isolation, even if more work.
FASTEST to implement	Least setup now, even if it costs more to run.
Which service is designed to	The service whose primary purpose this is, not one that could be made to do it.

ON THE EXAM

AWS capitalises these words on purpose. When you see one, decide what it eliminates before reading the options.

A reading order that works

01

Read the last line first

The actual question is at the end. Read it before the scenario.

02

Find the qualifier

MOST, LEAST, designed to. Note what it eliminates.

03

Read the scenario for constraints

Underline requirements mentally. Each one kills options.

04

Predict before reading options

Say the answer to yourself first, then look for it.

05

Eliminate, do not select

Remove options that break a stated constraint. What remains is the answer.

ON THE EXAM

Predicting before you read the options is the single highest-value habit. It stops plausible distractors anchoring you.

Distractor patterns AWS reuses

- ◆ **The right answer to a different question.** A sensible action nobody asked for. The commonest of all.
- ◆ **The heavier version.** Works, but takes more effort than the scenario needs. Loses on LEAST overhead.
- ◆ **The adjacent service.** Same category, wrong job. Inspector for a behaviour question, GuardDuty for a vulnerability one.
- ◆ **The absolute.** Options containing all, always, never, unlimited or eliminates entirely are usually wrong.
- ◆ **The name collision.** Direct Connect and Amazon Connect. Read the whole name.

ON THE EXAM

If two options are the same shape and one is heavier, the lighter one is usually correct on this exam.

Five more patterns worth naming

- ◆ **Mitigate instead of eliminate.** Three options manage a flaw better; one removes it. The exam wants the one that removes it.
- ◆ **The half solution.** The scenario names two problems and the option fixes one. It feels productive and scores nothing.
- ◆ **The invented feature.** Real vocabulary borrowed from a neighbouring service. Multi-AZ is real, but not for EBS volumes.
- ◆ **Correct but off-question.** A factually true statement that answers something nobody asked.
- ◆ **The near-miss number.** Right shape, wrong figure. Thirty minutes when the stem said fifteen.

ON THE EXAM

If an option describes a feature you have never met, suspect invention before assuming you missed it.

Four kinds of clause in a stem

CLAUSE TYPE	SIGNAL WORDS	WHAT IT DOES
Goal	wants to, needs to, so that	Picks the answer
Constraint	must, required, cannot, without	Eliminates options before anything else
Preference	would prefer, would like, ideally	Breaks a tie, but never beats a constraint
Invitation	willing to, able to, open to	Permits an approach the question wants you to choose

ON THE EXAM

The goal picks the answer; the constraint eliminates. Confusing the two is the commonest reading error on this exam.

Multiple choice or multiple response?

MULTIPLE CHOICE

One correct, three distractors

- Exactly one option is right
- Partial credit does not exist
- Eliminate to one
- The majority of the paper

MULTIPLE RESPONSE

Two or more correct, five or more options

- The stem tells you how many to choose
- No partial credit. All or nothing.
- Usually two separate requirements
- Roughly one question in ten

THE TIEBREAKER

On a Choose two, look for two distinct requirements in the scenario. One service each is the usual design.

Time and the flag button

- ◆ **Ninety minutes for sixty five questions** is about eighty three seconds each. Most people finish with time spare.
- ◆ Flag anything that takes more than about ninety seconds and move on immediately.
- ◆ Second-pass flagged questions with fresh eyes. Later questions often remind you of something.
- ◆ **Answer every question before the first pass ends**, even flagged ones. Never leave a blank.
- ◆ Do not change an answer on a third look unless you can name what you misread.

ON THE EXAM

Fifteen of the sixty five are unscored and unmarked. The hardest question you meet may not count at all.

When you genuinely do not know

- ◆ **Eliminate absolutes first.** Any option promising all, always, never or unlimited.
- ◆ **Eliminate anything requiring you to manage servers** if the qualifier says least overhead.
- ◆ **Prefer the purpose-built service** over the general one that could be configured to do it.
- ◆ **Prefer the AWS-managed option** over building it yourself. This exam consistently rewards managed.
- ◆ **If a service is not on the in-scope list**, it is very unlikely to be the answer.

ON THE EXAM

These heuristics are worth roughly a mark or two. Use them only after real elimination has failed.

A company needs to run a nightly job that resizes images. The job takes about four minutes, runs once a day, and the company does not want to manage any infrastructure.

Four options are given. The question ends with the phrase: which solution will meet these requirements with the LEAST operational overhead?

Which option does the qualifier point at?

- ☐ A An EC2 instance with a cron job
- ☐ B An Auto Scaling group scaled to zero overnight
- ☐ C An AWS Lambda function on a schedule
- ☐ D An Amazon EKS cluster running a CronJob

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which option does the qualifier point at?

- A

 An EC2 instance with a cron job
Works, and is cheap if the instance is stopped. But you patch and manage an operating system.
- B

 An Auto Scaling group scaled to zero overnight
The heavier version. All of A's overhead plus scaling configuration, for a job that never needs to scale.
- C

 An AWS Lambda function on a schedule
No servers, no patching, no capacity. Four minutes is inside Lambda's fifteen-minute limit.
- D

 An Amazon EKS cluster running a CronJob
Enormously heavier. A Kubernetes control plane to resize images once a night.

THE SIGNAL

LEAST operational overhead ranks the options: serverless, then managed, then self-run. Cost was never mentioned.

Same nightly image job as before, but the question now ends: which solution will meet these requirements MOST cost-effectively? The company adds that it already runs a fleet of EC2 instances that sit at low utilisation overnight.

The job is stateless and can be restarted if interrupted.

Does the answer change?

- ☐ A No. Lambda is still correct because it is serverless
- ☐ B Yes. Run the job on the existing under-used instances
- ☐ C Yes. Move the entire fleet to Spot Instances
- ☐ D No. The qualifier does not affect service selection

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Does the answer change?

- A

 No. Lambda is still correct because it is serverless
Serverless answers overhead, not cost. Capacity you already pay for overnight is cheaper than new invocations.
- B

 Yes. Run the job on the existing under-used instances
The capacity is already bought and idle. Using it adds no marginal cost.
- C

 Yes. Move the entire fleet to Spot Instances
Solves a problem nobody asked about, and re-architects a production fleet for a nightly job.
- D

 No. The qualifier does not affect service selection
The qualifier is often the only thing that separates two otherwise valid answers.

THE SIGNAL

Same scenario, one changed qualifier, different answer. This is why you find the qualifier before reading options.

A question reads: a company wants to improve its security posture. Which AWS service should the company use? The four options are Amazon GuardDuty, Amazon Inspector, AWS Security Hub and Amazon Macie.

The scenario gives no other detail at all.

What should you do with a question like this?

- ☐ A Pick GuardDuty, the most commonly correct security service
- ☐ B Reread the stem for the detail that distinguishes them; there is always one
- ☐ C Flag it and guess at the end
- ☐ D Pick Security Hub, since it aggregates the other three

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should you do with a question like this?

- A

 Pick GuardDuty, the most commonly correct security service
Answer frequency across a bank tells you nothing about this question. There is no statistical shortcut.
- B

 Reread the stem for the detail that distinguishes them; there is always one
AWS does not ship questions with four equally correct answers. If they all fit, you have missed a word.
- C

 Flag it and guess at the end
Reasonable fallback, but only after rereading. Flagging first wastes the second look too.
- D

 Pick Security Hub, since it aggregates the other three
Aggregation is not automatically the answer. Security Hub is correct only when the requirement is central findings.

THE SIGNAL

If every option looks correct, you have missed a constraint. That feeling is information, not bad luck.

Consider this stem. A company wants to reduce the time it takes to provision test environments. Regulation requires that all test data remains within the United Kingdom. The team would prefer a solution its engineers already know. The company is willing to adopt new tooling if necessary.

Which clause will eliminate the most answer options?

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ A Wants to reduce provisioning time | ☐ B Regulation requires data remains in the United Kingdom |
| ☐ C Would prefer something engineers already know | ☐ D Is willing to adopt new tooling |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which clause will eliminate the most answer options?

- | | |
|---|---|
| <p>A Wants to reduce provisioning time
<i>This is the goal. It selects between surviving options rather than removing any.</i></p> <p>C Would prefer something engineers already know
<i>A preference. It breaks a tie at the very end, and option D has already weakened it.</i></p> | <p>B Regulation requires data remains in the United Kingdom
<i>A hard constraint. Any option placing data elsewhere is gone before the goal is considered.</i></p> <p>D Is willing to adopt new tooling
<i>An invitation. It opens options up rather than closing them, and it directly cancels clause C.</i></p> |
|---|---|

THE SIGNAL

Constraints eliminate, goals select, preferences tie-break, invitations permit. Work them in that order.

The evening before

- ◆ Rewatch the confusion pairs module. It is built for exactly this moment.
- ◆ Reread the in-scope and out-of-scope service lists in the exam guide. Ten minutes, high value.
- ◆ Do not take a fresh practice exam the night before. A poor score costs you sleep and teaches nothing new.
- ◆ **If testing online with OnVUE**, run the system test in advance and clear your desk completely.
- ◆ You do not need to pass every domain. Compensatory scoring means one weak area cannot fail you alone.

ON THE EXAM

Confidence on this exam comes from having a procedure for hard questions, not from having seen every service.